Participatory Research and Practice Innovation

Learner guide | SWP-034 | School of Community & Macro Practice

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Participatory Research and Practice Innovation. By the end of the course, you should be able to plan a small, ethical, participatory practice inquiry and use the findings with communities to test and improve a service within a professional role.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Plan a small, ethical, participatory practice inquiry and use the findings with communities to test and improve a service within a professional role.
- Apply the key ideas from Practice questions and meaningful participation.
- Apply the key ideas from Ethical inquiry and interpretation.
- Apply the key ideas from Responsible innovation and learning.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. Practice questions and meaningful participation	question framing, positionality, consent, power, lived experience, co-research, and meaningful involvement	10 to 15 minutes
2. Ethical inquiry and interpretation	proportionate data collection, data minimisation, confidentiality, accessibility, bias, evidence limits, and transparent interpretation	10 to 15 minutes
3. Responsible innovation and learning	bounded pilots, feedback, implementation risks, decision criteria, documenting adaptations, escalation, and sharing learning with participants	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 Practice questions and meaningful participation

This module focuses on question framing, positionality, consent, power, lived experience, co-research, and meaningful involvement. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Question framing
- Positionality
- Consent
- Power
- Lived experience
- Co-research
- Meaningful involvement

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of practice questions and meaningful participation in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of question framing, positionality, consent, power, lived experience, co-research, and meaningful involvement. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through practice questions and meaningful participation safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 Ethical inquiry and interpretation

This module focuses on proportionate data collection, data minimisation, confidentiality, accessibility, bias, evidence limits, and transparent interpretation. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Proportionate data collection
- Data minimisation
- Confidentiality
- Accessibility
- Bias
- Evidence limits
- Transparent interpretation

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of ethical inquiry and interpretation in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of proportionate data collection, data minimisation, confidentiality, accessibility, bias, evidence limits, and transparent interpretation. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through ethical inquiry and interpretation safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Responsible innovation and learning

This module focuses on bounded pilots, feedback, implementation risks, decision criteria, documenting adaptations, escalation, and sharing learning with participants. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Bounded pilots
- Feedback
- Implementation risks
- Decision criteria
- Documenting adaptations
- Escalation
- Sharing learning with participants

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of responsible innovation and learning in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of bounded pilots, feedback, implementation risks, decision criteria, documenting adaptations, escalation, and sharing learning with participants. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through responsible innovation and learning safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: question framing.
- Review the distinction between: meaningful participation.
- Review the distinction between: informed consent.
- Review the distinction between: data minimisation.
- Review the distinction between: evidence limits.
- Review the distinction between: pilot safeguards.
- Review the distinction between: learning decisions.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.